



Caper's buds pickled with vinegar have been used as a condiment since ancient times.

The root bark is purifying and stops internal bleeding. It is used to treat skin conditions, capillary weakness, and easy bruising, and is also used in cosmetic preparations. A decoction of the plant is used to treat yeast and vaginal infections such as candidiasis.

Related Species A decoction of the North American *C. cynophallophora* is taken to encourage the onset of menstruation, and is used as a gargle for throat infections.

Capsella bursa-pastoris syn. *Thlaspi bursa-pastoris* (Brassicaceae) Shepherd's Purse

Description Annual or biennial with an erect stem, rosette of basal leaves, 4-petaled white flowers, and heart-shaped seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation Thought to be native to Europe and Asia, shepherd's purse is now found throughout most temperate regions, and grows profusely as a weed. It is harvested throughout the year.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Contains flavonoids, polypeptides, choline, acetylcholine, histamine, and tyramine.

History & Folklore This herb's name derives from the appearance of the seed pods, which resemble heart-shaped purses. During the First World War, when the standard herbal medicines

for staunching blood—goldenseal (*Hydrastis canadensis*, p. 105) and ergot (*Claviceps purpurea*)—were unobtainable in Britain, shepherd's purse was used as an alternative.

Medicinal Actions & Uses One of the best remedies for preventing or arresting hemorrhage, shepherd's purse has long been a specific treatment for heavy uterine bleeding. While weaker-acting in this respect than ergot, shepherd's purse has none of ergot's toxicity and is better tolerated by the body. It may be used for bleeding of all kinds—from nosebleeds to blood in the urine. An astringent herb, it disinfects the urinary tract in cases of cystitis, and is taken for diarrhea. It is used in Chinese medicine to treat dysentery and eye problems.

Research Reports suggest that the plant is anti-inflammatory and reduces fever.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Self-help Use Heavy menstrual bleeding, p. 315.

Cardiospermum spp. (Sapindaceae) Balloon Vine

Description Deciduous perennial climbers growing to 10 ft (3 m), with compound leaves, small white flowers, and black seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Balloon vine is found growing in tropical regions around the world.

Parts Used Root, leaves, seeds.



Balloon vine leaves are applied to relieve aching joints.

Constituents Most *Cardiospermum* species contain cyanogenic glycosides.

History & Folklore Native Amazonians string balloon vine seeds into armbands that are worn to ward off snakes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Indian herbal medicine, balloon vine root is used to bring on delayed menstruation and to relieve backache and arthritis. The leaves stimulate local circulation and are applied to painful joints to help speed the clearing of toxins. The seeds are also thought to help in the treatment of arthritis. The plant as a whole has sedative properties.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Carica papaya (Caricaceae) Papaya

Description Herbaceous tree growing very rapidly to 26 ft (8 m). Has segmented leaves, yellow flowers, and large, black-seeded yellow to orange fruits weighing up to 11 lb (5 kg).

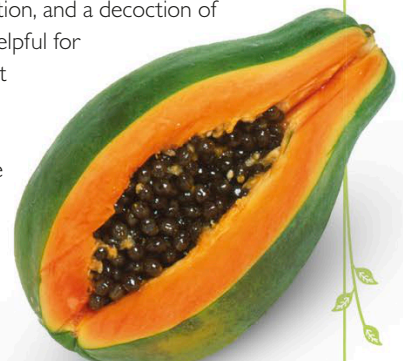
Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical America, papaya is now cultivated in tropical regions throughout the world.

Parts Used Fruit, latex, leaves, flowers, seeds.

Constituents The fruit contains proteolytic enzymes (papain and chymopapain), and traces of an alkaloid, carpaine. Papain, which is found in the milky white latex that flows from incisions in the unripe fruit, is a protein-dissolving enzyme that aids digestion.

History & Folklore Papaya juice, shoots, and latex were used in Mayan herbal medicine. In tropical Latin America, the leaves are used as a meat tenderizer.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Papaya's main medicinal use is as a digestive agent. The leaves and the fruit can both be used (the unripe fruit is especially effective). The latex from the trunk of the tree is applied externally to speed the healing of wounds, ulcers, boils, warts, and cancerous tumors. The seeds are used as a gentle purgative for worms. The latex has a similar but more violent effect. The flowers may be taken in an infusion to induce menstruation, and a decoction of the ripe fruit is helpful for treating persistent diarrhea and dysentery in children. The ripe fruit is mildly laxative and the leaves are used to dress wounds.



Fruit